

RANJAN RAHI

CASE STUDY

Ritik Kumar, 21, Patna

Salesperson at a clothing store

Monthly income: Rs 15,000

Trained as: Plumber

Just a Pipe Dream

When he completed a plumbing course at the local Industrial Training Institute (ITI) in 2024 post matriculation, Ritik had hoped he would finally be able to supplement the family income. His father works at a private hospital, earning around Rs 12,000 a month. But despite repeated efforts, Ritik failed to find a job as a plumber. Visits to several recruitment agencies ended with the same response: most of the available opportunities were either in metropolitan cities or abroad, particularly in the Gulf countries. Since his modest background did not allow him to relocate to another city, travel overseas or continue to pay recruitment commissions, Ritik took up a job as a salesperson in a clothing shop to earn an immediate income. But he hasn't given up hope entirely. He continues to apply for plumbing-related positions in government departments, including the Public Health Engineering Department (PHED), and hopes to eventually find work in the field in which he trained.

—Amitabh Srivastava

trades attract a premium. However, even today, schools are not equipped to integrate vocational education effectively. "Right now, adoption is minuscule as the curriculum framework on how schools should implement vocational education is a recent phenomenon," says Dewan of JustJobs Network. "We need a much more concerted push to implement it effectively."

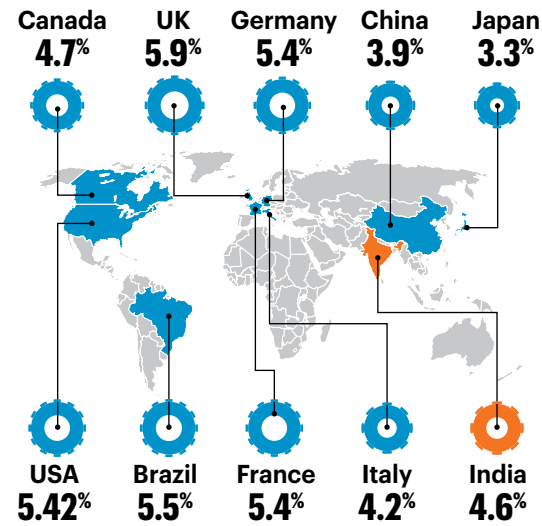
NITI Aayog's 'School Education System in India' 2026 report highlights several other issues. Most vocational courses are offered as optional subjects, not given adequate instructional time, and are often seen as options for academically weaker students. Many schools lack the infrastructure needed for hands-on and experiential learning—workshops, laboratories, industrial equipment—even as trainers are in short supply. The report cites a 2023 review by the ministry of education that found more than 40 per cent of sanctioned vocational trainer posts vacant in several states.

India also seriously lags in investment in vocational education and training (VET), allocating only around 3 per cent of total education spend to vocational training in 2021, compared with the 10-13 per cent spend on VET institutions in Germany, Singapore and Canada, according to a December 2025 study by NCAER (National Council of Applied Economic Research), 'India's Employment Prospects: Pathways to Jobs'.

EDUCATION: NOT SPENDING ENOUGH

At 4.6 per cent of GDP, education spending remains below the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 target of 6 per cent, trailing behind several major economies

GOVT EXPENDITURE ON EDUCATION (% OF GDP)



Source: 'School Education System in India', NITI Aayog, May '26